

Opinion of the Court

tory or constitutional right, and (2) the unlawfulness of their conduct was “clearly established at the time.” *Reichle v. Howards*, 566 U.S. 658, 664 (2012). “Clearly established” means that, at the time of the officer’s conduct, the law was “‘sufficiently clear’ that every ‘reasonable official would understand that what he is doing’” is unlawful. *al-Kidd, supra*, at 741 (quoting *Anderson v. Creighton*, 483 U.S. 635, 640 (1987)). In other words, existing law must have placed the constitutionality of the officer’s conduct “beyond debate.” *al-Kidd, supra*, at 741. This demanding standard protects “all but the plainly incompetent or those who knowingly violate the law.” *Malley v. Briggs*, 475 U.S. 335, 341 (1986).

To be clearly established, a legal principle must have a sufficiently clear foundation in then-existing precedent. The rule must be “settled law,” *Hunter v. Bryant*, 502 U.S. 224, 228 (1991) (*per curiam*), which means it is dictated by “controlling authority” or “a robust ‘consensus of cases of persuasive authority,’” *al-Kidd, supra*, at 741–742 (quoting *Wilson v. Layne*, 526 U.S. 603, 617 (1999)). It is not enough that the rule is suggested by then-existing precedent. The precedent must be clear enough that every reasonable official would interpret it to establish the particular rule the plaintiff seeks to apply. See *Reichle*, 566 U.S., at 666. Otherwise, the rule is not one that “every reasonable official” would know. *Id.*, at 664 (internal quotation marks omitted).

The “clearly established” standard also requires that the legal principle clearly prohibit the officer’s conduct in the particular circumstances before him. The rule’s contours must be so well defined that it is “clear to a reasonable officer that his conduct was unlawful in the situation he confronted.” *Saucier v. Katz*, 533 U.S. 194, 202 (2001). This requires a high “degree of specificity.” *Mullenix v. Luna*, 577 U.S. 7, 13 (2015) (*per curiam*). We have repeatedly stressed that courts must not “define clearly established law at a high level of generality, since doing so avoids the crucial question whether the official acted reasonably in the particular cir-